

Standard Operating Procedure

Hand Tool Safety Procedure

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Applicable Jurisdiction	Ontario (see Note for Manitoba)
Document Owner	Operations / H&S Lead

1. Purpose

This procedure establishes minimum safety requirements for the selection, inspection, use, maintenance, and storage of hand tools by technicians performing low-voltage and structured cabling work at commercial and institutional sites. It is intended to prevent lacerations, punctures, eye injuries, strains, and property/utility damage arising from hand tool use.

2. Scope

This procedure applies to all employees, subcontractors, and site personnel of the Company using manual (non-powered) hand tools during installation, termination, testing, or service work, including but not limited to:

- Screwdrivers, nut drivers, and torque tools
- Wire strippers, cable cutters, and crimpers
- Punch-down tools (110/66 blocks)
- Pliers, diagonal cutters, and multi-tools
- Utility knives and cable jacket slitters
- Fish tape, fish rods, and pull tools
- Hammers, punches, and chisels used for anchoring or fastening

This procedure does not cover powered tools (drills, rotary hammers) — see SOP-LV-002 for concrete drilling — or fall protection/ladder procedures, which are addressed separately.

3. References

- Ontario Occupational Health and Safety Act (OHSA), R.S.O. 1990
- O. Reg. 213/91 — Construction Projects
- CSA Z94.3 — Eye and Face Protectors
- CSA Z195 — Protective Footwear
- ANSI/ISEA 105 — Hand Protection Classification
- WSIB reporting requirements for workplace injuries
- Company SOP-LV-003 — Ontario Jobsite Health & Safety Checklist

Note — Manitoba jurisdiction: for work performed in Manitoba, references to OHSA and O. Reg. 213/91 are replaced by The Workplace Safety and Health Act (Manitoba) and Man. Reg. 217/2006; WSIB reporting is replaced by WCB Manitoba. Confirm the applicable version of this SOP with the H&S lead before use on Manitoba sites.

4. Responsibilities

Supervisor / Site Lead

- Confirms technicians have received hand tool safety orientation before independent field work
- Conducts periodic spot checks of tool condition and use practices
- Delivers toolbox talks referencing this SOP and logs them in the Supervisor Acknowledgement table (Section 11)
- Ensures damaged or defective tools are removed from service immediately

Technician

- Inspects tools before each use per Section 5
- Uses each tool only for its designed purpose
- Wears the PPE specified in Section 6 for the task being performed
- Reports damaged tools, near misses, and injuries to the Supervisor immediately
- Signs the acknowledgement table in Section 10 confirming understanding of this procedure

5. Pre-Use Inspection

Before each use, technicians must visually and physically inspect hand tools for:

- Cracked, splintered, or loose handles
- Mushroomed or chipped striking faces (hammers, punches, chisels)
- Dull, chipped, or misaligned cutting edges (strippers, cutters, knives)
- Damaged or missing insulation on tools used near energized conductors
- Proper function of retractable blades and locking mechanisms
- Corrosion or excessive wear at pivot points (pliers, crimpers)

Any tool that fails inspection must be tagged out of service, removed from the work area, and reported to the Supervisor. Do not attempt field repair of striking or cutting tools.

6. Personal Protective Equipment

Minimum PPE by task category is summarized below. Site-specific requirements in SOP-LV-003 take precedence where more stringent.

Task / Tool Category	Minimum Required PPE
Cutting, stripping, crimping (cable tools)	Safety glasses (CSA Z94.3); cut-resistant gloves when handling stranded/armored cable
Striking tools (hammers, punches, chisels)	Safety glasses with side shields; gloves removed for tools requiring fine grip control
Fish tape / rod work in ceilings or walls	Safety glasses, gloves, hard hat if working below others or near overhead hazards
Utility knives / cable strippers	Cut-resistant gloves rated ANSI/ISEA A2 or higher; cut away from body
Ladder-supported hand tool use	CSA-approved footwear, three-point contact maintained, tools carried in a pouch/holster — not by hand

7. Safe Use Practices

General

- Select the correct tool for the task; never use a tool beyond its rated capacity
- Cut and pull away from the body and away from other workers
- Keep cutting edges pointed away from hands, cords, and colleagues when carrying
- Never carry exposed cutting or striking tools in pockets
- Maintain a clean, dry grip; wipe tools before use in wet or greasy conditions
- De-energize and verify absence of voltage before using hand tools near exposed conductors
- Store tools in a pouch, roll, or box when not in use — never leave loose on ladders, ceiling grids, or floor openings

Striking Tools

- Use a hammer/punch with a face condition appropriate to the striking surface; replace mushroomed heads immediately
- Ensure a firm handle grip and clear swing path before striking

Cutting and Stripping Tools

- Confirm cable is de-energized (data/comm cabling only — never cut suspected live low-voltage circuits without verification)
- Use the correct stripper gauge for cable size to avoid conductor nicking
- Dispose of cut jacket scraps and drops in a designated container, not on walking surfaces

Fish Tape / Fish Rod

- Treat all fish tape as a potential conductor; do not use near energized panels or conduits with unknown contents
- Wear gloves and safety glasses; feed and retrieve with controlled tension to avoid recoil injury

8. Prohibited Practices

- Using pliers or wrenches as a substitute for a hammer
- Using a screwdriver as a chisel or pry bar
- Using a knife or stripper blade toward the body or supporting hand
- Using tools with damaged insulation on or near energized equipment
- Modifying a tool (e.g., grinding, extending handles) outside manufacturer specification
- Continued use of a tool after it has failed inspection under Section 5

9. Incident and Near-Miss Reporting

Any injury, near miss, or property/utility damage involving hand tool use must be reported to the Supervisor immediately and documented per the Company incident reporting process (see IR-2026-07-08-001 for a prior example following the Elsie McGill Public School incident). Reports must be filed the same shift where practicable, with WSIB notification timelines followed for reportable injuries.

10. Technician Acknowledgement

By signing below, each technician confirms they have read, understood, and agree to follow this Hand Tool Safety Procedure (SOP-LV-008), and have been given the opportunity to ask questions.

Technician Name (Print)	Signature	Date

11. Supervisor Toolbox Talk Log

Supervisors record delivery of the associated toolbox talk below.

Supervisor Name (Print)	Signature	Date	Toolbox Talk Delivered (Y/N)

Supervisor Name (Print)	Signature	Date	Toolbox Talk Delivered (Y/N)